

Does Medicine have a Philosophy?

Prof. Ashish Karn

धर्मार्थकाममोक्षाणामारोग्यं मूलमुत्तमम् ॥ रोगास्तस्यापहर्तारः श्रेयसो जीवितस्य च । - आचार्य चरक

Health is the supreme foundation of dharma, artha, kāma, and mokṣa. Disease destroys that foundation, as well as human welfare and life itself. - Ācārya Charaka

The greatest mistake in the treatment of diseases is that there are physicians for the body and physicians for the soul, although the two cannot be separated. - Plato

When we visit a hospital, we rarely stop to think about why doctors ask the questions they do. Imagine arriving at the emergency department with severe chest pain. Within minutes, nurses attach a heart monitor, blood samples are collected, an electrocardiogram is performed, and perhaps a CT scan or an angiogram follows. Physicians carefully examine your blood pressure, cholesterol levels, cardiac enzymes, and imaging reports before deciding upon the most appropriate treatment. To us, this sequence appears entirely natural. It is simply what doctors do.

Yet pause for a moment and consider a different question. Why were these particular tests performed? Why did the physician focus on your heart, your arteries, and your blood chemistry? Why was so much attention given to **measurable** biological changes alone? The answer is not that these questions are the only important ones. Rather, physicians ask the questions that make sense within the medical tradition in which they have been trained. Every system of medicine begins with certain assumptions about what health is, what disease is, what causes illness, and what the physician's role ought to be. Those assumptions quietly determine what is examined, what is measured, what counts as evidence, and ultimately how treatment is planned.

Most of us think of medicine simply as science applied to the human body. In reality, science alone cannot decide which questions are worth asking. For that matter, is there **only one universal way to do science** (even of medicine!)? Before any observations are made or experiments are performed, medicine must first decide what it wishes to understand. Every medical tradition makes certain philosophical assumptions. Those assumptions illuminate some aspects of health while pushing others into the background.

A Few Questions Before We Begin

Let's look at these philosophical questions, and see if you have a "clear" answer to them:

- What is a human being?
- What is a medicine?
- What is the goal of medicine?
- What is "good health" for?
- What is a disease? Should disease be treated only when it manifests?
- Should every patient suffering from an ailment be treated in the same way? And so on...

Now, think: Can there ever be a medical system that is completely free of philosophy? Why ?

Recognize that even modern scientific medicine rests on philosophical commitments, often without making them explicit. Thus, Ayurveda is not an "alternative medicine," but an alternative framework for understanding health, which is precisely the perspective this course seeks to develop.

A Brief Historical Detour

The medicine practiced in hospitals today is the result of a remarkable intellectual journey. For much of history, physicians were also philosophers. Understanding disease meant understanding nature, the human body, and humanity's place within the larger order of the world. Healing was therefore closely connected with broader questions about life, balance, and purpose. One physician reflecting on this history writes that medicine and religion once shared a common orientation, giving rise to the ideal of the physician-priest-philosopher - one who cared not only for the body but also for the human being as a whole (Kurapati, 2018).

A profound transformation began during the Scientific Revolution in Europe. Thinkers such as Francis Bacon argued that reliable knowledge should rest upon observation, experimentation, and measurable evidence rather than philosophical speculation. This change transformed medicine. Anatomy was explored with unprecedented precision, microorganisms were discovered, physiology flourished, and diseases gradually became understandable in terms of observable biological processes. By concentrating on questions that could be measured and experimentally verified, medicine became one of the most successful scientific disciplines in human history.

The achievements of this approach are extraordinary. Anaesthesia has made complex surgery possible, and modern imaging allows physicians to look inside the living body without making a single incision. Yet every way of looking at the world also has its natural boundaries. Modern medicine became exceptionally good at answering questions about how disease develops. It explains how bacteria cause pneumonia, how arteries become blocked, how genes influence inherited disorders, and how cancer cells multiply.

Patients, however, often ask different questions. Medical jargon alone seldom satisfies them. They ask why illness has entered their lives, why it appeared now, whether years of stress, habits, relationships, or environment played a role, and how they should live after recovering from disease. As one physician candidly observes,

“Modern medicine remains ill-equipped to answer the patient’s questions: Why me? Why specifically me? Why should I suffer?” (Kurapati, 2018).

This does not imply that modern medicine has failed. Every discipline has a scope. Modern medicine has chosen to investigate those aspects of disease that can be observed, measured, and experimentally tested.

Once we recognize this, another important insight follows. If different medical traditions begin with different philosophical assumptions, they will naturally ask different questions about the same patient. A medical system that defines health primarily as the absence of disease will naturally focus on diagnosis and treatment. Another system that understands health as a state of balance and adaptation may devote greater attention to daily habits, diet, environment, emotional well-being, and prevention.

This course is therefore not an invitation to compare one medical system against another or to choose between them. Before studying Ayurveda, we shall first try to understand the philosophical foundations from which it emerged. Like every mature medical tradition, Ayurveda begins with its own understanding of the human being, health, disease, and healing. Once we understand these foundational ideas, we shall be in a much better position to appreciate how they shaped its methods of diagnosis, prevention, and treatment over many centuries.

The more fundamental question is this: What kind of questions does Ayurveda ask about health that modern medicine does not, and why?

References

Kurapati, R. (2018). *Physician: How Science Transformed the Art of Medicine*. Greenleaf Book Group.